

Ancient History — UPSC Prelims PYQ

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— 2026 —

UPSC 2026

Ancient History › Vedic Period

difficult

Q1. Consider the following assertion :

In the Pleistocene period either the Yamuna once flowed into the Indus, or the Sutlej flowed into the Yamuna and one major tributary of either had shifted from the Ganga to the Indus or vice versa.

Which of the following is/are the basis of the above assertion ?

- 1. The Nadi-Sukta of the Rigveda**
- 2. The explorations of the Sutlej and the Yamuna by Robert Bruce Foote**
- 3. The presence of the same species of dolphins in both the Indus and the Ganga river systems**

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 1 and 2
- (d) 3**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 2026

Ancient History › Vedic Period

moderate

Q3. Which of the following pairs of ancient and modern names of rivers is/are correctly matched ?

- 1. Vitasta : Chenab**
- 2. Asikni : Jhelum**
- 3. Parushni : Ravi**
- 4. Yavyavati : Beas**

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 3 and 4
- (c) 3 only**
- (d) 4 only

Answer: (c)

Q5. Which of the following pairs of the king and his dynasty in early historical Tamilakam is/are not correctly matched ?

1. Senguttuvan : Chera
2. Udiyanjeral : Chola
3. Nedunjeliyan : Pandya

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 2 only**
- (c) 1 and 3
- (d) 3 only

Answer: (b)

Q10. In which one among the following texts does the term kshetra-patni ('mistress of the field') originate ?

- (a) Rigveda
- (b) Atharvaveda**
- (c) Ashtadhyayi
- (d) Arthashastra

Answer: (b)

Q13. Consider the following statements :

I. Pali texts contain the first definite references to coins, e.g., kahapana, nikkha, kamsa, and kakanika.

II. The literary evidence from Pali texts is corroborated by archaeological evidence of punch-marked coins from many sites, most of them made of silver.

The above statements have been associated with which of the following ?

1. Emergence of urban life
2. Transition to money economy

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2**
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c)

Q17. Consider the following statements relating to the use of the place-value system in India :

- 1. The earliest epigraphic use of the place-value system in India is found in the Mankani plates from Gujarat (AD 595 – 596).**
- 2. In the ninth century, place-values become general in inscriptions all over India.**
- 3. The place-values have been found in Sanskrit inscriptions in South-east Asia as early as the seventh century.**

Which of the statements given above are correct ?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

Answer: (d)

Q18. Consider the following statements about the archaeological findings in Harappan towns :

- I. There is wide occurrence of spindle-whorls in the houses but absence of spinning wheels.**
- II. Weights and measurement scales, complete with graduations have been discovered.**
- III. There are houses built in large part with baked bricks, around relatively spacious courtyards, with their own wells, bathing platforms, and large rooms.**

Which of the following inferences can be drawn from the above statements ?

- 1. Statement I suggests that spinning was a laborious activity done at home.**
- 2. Statement II suggests the extent of the scientific knowledge that the Harappans possessed.**
- 3. Statement III suggests the emergence of a common property system.**

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 and 2 only**
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a)

Q20. Consider the following statements about the Rigvedic period :

I. Irrigation from wells allowed agriculture to expand away from flood plains and strips on river margins into the present Punjab and Haryana plains having underground water levels reasonably close to the surface.

II. Draught-animal power was employed to draw up water out of the wells.

Which of the following information support/supports the above statements ?

- 1. There is evidence in the Rigveda of the use of ashma chakra (stone pulley wheel) and ahava (strapped wooden pails) to draw up water.**
- 2. Mention has been made in the Rigveda of the use of implements like parashu/kulisha (axe) and datra /sreni (sickle).**
- 3. There is a history of the use of ox, even before the Rigveda, for ploughing the land and pulling the carts.**

Select the answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1, 2 and 3
- (c) 1 and 3 only**
- (d) 3 only

Answer: (c)

— 2025 —

Q13. The irrigation device called 'Araghatta' was

- (a) a water bag made of leather pulled over a pulley
- (b) a large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes**
- (c) a larger earthen pot driven by bullocks
- (d) a large water bucket pulled up by rope directly by hand

Answer: (b)

Q14. Who among the following rulers in ancient India had assumed the titles 'Mattavilasa', 'Vichitrachitta' and 'Gunabhara'?

- (a) Mahendravarman I**
- (b) Simhavishnu
- (c) Narasimhavarman I
- (d) Simhavarman

Answer: (a)

Q15. Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of

- (a) Samudragupta
- (b) Chandragupta II**
- (c) Kumaragupta I
- (d) Skandagupta

Answer: (b)

Q16. Who among the following led a successful military campaign against the kingdom of Srivijaya, the powerful maritime State, which ruled the Malay Peninsula, Sumatra, Java and the neighbouring islands?

- (a) Amoghavarsha (Rashtrakuta)
- (b) Prataparudra (Kakatiya)
- (c) Rajendra I (Chola)**
- (d) Vishnuvardhana (Hoysala)

Answer: (c)

**Q17. With reference to ancient India (600–322 BC), consider the following pairs :
Territorial region : River flowing in the region**

I. Asmaka : Godavari

II. Kamboja : Vipas

III. Avanti : Mahanadi

IV. Kosala : Sarayu

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two**
- (c) Only three
- (d) All the four

Answer: (b)

Q19. Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at the

- (a) village-level administration
- (b) district-level administration**
- (c) provincial administration
- (d) level of the central administration

Answer: (b)

Q72. The famous female figurine known as 'Dancing Girl', found at Mohenjo-daro, is made of

- (a) carnelian
- (b) clay
- (c) bronze**
- (d) gold

Answer: (c)

— 2024 —

Q55. Consider the following information :

Archaeological Site | State | Description

- 1. Chandraketugarh | Odisha | Trading Port town**
- 2. Inamgaon | Maharashtra | Chalcolithic site**
- 3. Mangadu | Kerala | Megalithic site**
- 4. Salihundam | Andhra Pradesh | Rock-cut cave shrines**

In which of the above rows is the given information correctly matched ?

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 2 and 3**
- (c) 3 and 4
- (d) 1 and 4

Answer: (b)

— 2023 —

Q42. With reference to ancient India, consider the following statements :

- 1. The concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin.**
 - 2. Stupa was generally a repository of relics.**
 - 3. Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition.**
- How many of the statements given above are correct?**

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two**
- (c) All three
- (d) None

Answer: (b)

Q43. With reference to ancient South India, Korkai, Poompuhar and Muchiri were well known as

- (a) capital cities
- (b) ports**
- (c) centres of iron-and-steel making
- (d) shrines of Jain Tirthankaras

Answer: (b)

— 2022 —

Q60. According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, which of the following are correct ?

1. A person could be a slave as a result of a judicial punishment.
2. If a female slave bore her master a son, she was legally free.
3. If a son born to a female slave was fathered by her master, the son was entitled to the legal status of the master's son.

Which of the statements given above are correct ?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b)

Q91. Consider the following pairs :

Site of Ashoka's major rock edicts : Location in the State of

1. Dhauli — Odisha
2. Erragudi — Andhra Pradesh
3. Jaugada — Madhya Pradesh
4. Kalsi — Karnataka

How many pairs given above are correctly matched ?

- (a) Only one pair
- (b) Only two pairs**
- (c) Only three pairs
- (d) All four pairs

Answer: (b)

— 2021 —

UPSC 2021

Ancient History › Indus Valley Civilization

easy

Q32. Which one of the following ancient towns is well-known for its elaborate system of water harvesting and management by building a series of dams and channelizing water into connected reservoirs?

- (a) Dholavira**
- (b) Kalibangan
- (c) Rakhigarhi
- (d) Ropar

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2021

Ancient History › Post-Gupta & Early Medieval Dynasties

difficult

Q34. From the decline of Guptas until the rise of Harshavardhana in the early seventh century, which of the following kingdoms were holding power in Northern India?

1. The Guptas of Magadha
2. The Paramaras of Malwa
3. The Pushyabhutis of Thanesar
4. The Maukharis of Kanauj
5. The Yadavas of Devagiri
6. The Maitrakas of Valabhi

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1, 2 and 5
- (b) 1, 3, 4 and 6**
- (c) 2, 3 and 4
- (d) 5 and 6

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2021

Ancient History › Archaeology & Epigraphy

moderate

Q37. Consider the following pairs :

(Historical place) (Well-known for)

1. Burzahom : Rock-cut shrines
2. Chandraketugarh : Terracotta art
3. Ganeshwar : Copper artefacts

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 2
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 2 and 3**

Answer: (d)

Q40. With reference to the history of ancient India, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. Mitakshara was the civil law for upper castes and Dayabhaga was the civil law for lower castes.
 2. In the Mitakshara system, the sons can claim right to the property during the lifetime of the father, whereas in the Dayabhaga system, it is only after the death of the father that the sons can claim right to the property.
 3. The Mitakshara system deals with the matters related to the property held by male members only of a family, whereas the Dayabhaga system deals with the matters related to the property held by both male and female members of a family.
- Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 2 only**
- (c) 1 and 3
- (d) 3 only

Answer: (b)

— 2020 —

Q22. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements :

1. Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism.
 2. Lokottaravadin sect was an offshoot of Mahasanghika sect of Buddhism.
 3. The deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered the Mahayana Buddhism.
- Which of the statements given above is/are correct ?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b)

Q24. Consider the following events in the history of India :

1. Rise of Pratiharas under King Bhoja
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman – I
3. Establishment of Chola power by Parantaka – I
4. Pala dynasty founded by Gopala

What is the correct chronological order of the above events, starting from the earliest time ?

- (a) 2 – 1 – 4 – 3
- (b) 3 – 1 – 4 – 2
- (c) 2 – 4 – 1 – 3**
- (d) 3 – 4 – 1 – 2

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2020

Ancient History › Trade & Economy

easy

Q25. Which of the following phrases defines the nature of the 'Hundi' generally referred to in the sources of the post-Harsha period ?

- (a) An advisory issued by the king to his subordinates
- (b) A diary to be maintained for daily accounts
- (c) A bill of exchange**
- (d) An order from the feudal lord to his subordinates

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2020

Ancient History › Society, Law & Administration

easy

Q29. With reference to the history of India, the terms "kulyavapa" and "dronavapa" denote

- (a) measurement of land**
- (b) coins of different monetary value
- (c) classification of urban land
- (d) religious rituals

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2020

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

moderate

**Q30. Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription ?
"Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely."**

- (a) Ashoka**
- (b) Samudragupta
- (c) Harshavardhana
- (d) Krishnadeva Raya

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2020

Ancient History › Buddhism & Jainism

moderate

Q71. With reference to the cultural history of India, consider the following pairs :

- 1. Parivrajaka — Renunciant and Wanderer**
- 2. Shramana — Priest with a high status**
- 3. Upasaka — Lay follower of Buddhism**

Which of the pairs given above are correctly matched ?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 1 and 3 only**
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2020

Ancient History › Gupta Empire

moderate

Q82. With reference to the period of Gupta dynasty in ancient India, the towns Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were well known as

- (a) ports handling foreign trade**
- (b) capitals of powerful kingdoms
- (c) places of exquisite stone art and architecture
- (d) important Buddhist pilgrimage centres

Answer: (a)

— 2019 —

UPSC 2019

Ancient History › Indus Valley Civilization

easy

Q7. Which one of the following is not a Harappan site?

- (a) Chanhudaro
- (b) Kot Diji
- (c) Sohgauna**
- (d) Desalpur

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2019

Ancient History › Ancient India

difficult

Q8. In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- (a) Kanganahalli**
- (b) Sanchi
- (c) Shahbazgarhi
- (d) Sohgauna

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2019

Ancient History › Gupta Empire

moderate

Q10. With reference to forced labour (Vishti) in India during the Gupta period, which one of the following statements is correct?

- (a) It was considered a source of income for the State, a sort of tax paid by the people.**
- (b) It was totally absent in the Madhya Pradesh and Kathiawar regions of the Gupta Empire.
- (c) The forced labourer was entitled to weekly wages.
- (d) The eldest son of the labourer was sent as the forced labourer.

Answer: (a)

— 2017 —

Q2. With reference to the difference between the culture of Rigvedic Aryans and Indus Valley people, which of the following statements is/are correct ?

1. Rigvedic Aryans used the coat of mail and helmet in warfare whereas the people of Indus Valley Civilization did not leave any evidence of using them.
2. Rigvedic Aryans knew gold, silver and copper whereas Indus Valley people knew only copper and iron.
3. Rigvedic Aryans had domesticated the horse whereas there is no evidence of Indus Valley people having been aware of this animal.

Select the correct answer using the code given below :

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c)

Q8. Which one of the following statements is correct ?

- (a) Rights are claims of the State against the citizens.
- (b) Rights are privileges which are incorporated in the Constitution of a State.
- (c) Rights are claims of the citizens against the State.**
- (d) Rights are privileges of a few citizens against the many.

Answer: (c)

Q53. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements :

1. Sautrantika and Sammitiya were the sects of Jainism.
2. Sarvastivadin held that the constituents of phenomena were not wholly momentary, but existed forever in a latent form.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct ?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only**
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2016

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

easy

Q39. Who of the following had first deciphered the edicts of Emperor Ashoka?

- (a) Georg Bühler
- (b) James Prinsep**
- (c) Max Müller
- (d) William Jones

Answer: (b)

— 2015 —

UPSC 2015

Ancient History › Mahajanapadas & Early Kingdoms

moderate

Q39. Which of the following kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

- 1. Avanti**
- 2. Gandhara**
- 3. Kosala**
- 4. Magadha**

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 4
- (d) 3 and 4 only**

Answer: (d)

— 2014 —

UPSC 2014

Ancient History › Mahajanapadas & Early Kingdoms

moderate

Q25. Which of the following Kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

- 1. Avanti**
- 2. Gandhara**
- 3. Kosala**
- 4. Magadha**

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 4
- (c) 3 and 4 only**
- (d) 1, 3 and 4

Answer: (c)

— 2013 —

Q6. The Chinese traveller Yuan Chwang (Hiuen Tsang) who visited India recorded the general conditions and culture of India at that time. In this context, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The roads and river-routes were completely immune from robbery.
2. As regards punishment for offences, ordeals by fire, water and poison were the instruments for determining the innocence or guilt of a person.
3. The tradesmen had to pay duties at ferries and barrier stations.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below.

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b)

Q45. Which of the following characterizes/characterize the people of Indus Civilization?

1. They possessed great palaces and temples.
2. They worshipped both male and female deities.
3. They employed horse-drawn chariots in warfare.

Select the correct statement/statements using the codes given below.

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only**
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) None of the statements given above is correct

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2012

Ancient History › Science & Technology

moderate

Q21. With reference to the scientific progress of ancient India, which of the statements given below are correct?

1. Different kinds of specialized surgical instruments were in common use by 1st century AD.
2. Transplant of internal organs in the human body had begun by the beginning of 3rd century AD.
3. The concept of sine of an angle was known in 5th century AD.
4. The concept of cyclic quadrilaterals was known in 7th century AD.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below :

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 and 4 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 4 only**
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2012

Ancient History › Buddhism & Jainism

easy

Q22. With reference to the history of ancient India, which of the following was/were common to both Buddhism and Jainism?

1. Avoidance of extremities of penance and enjoyment
2. Indifference to the authority of the Vedas
3. Denial of efficacy of rituals

Select the correct answer using the codes given below :

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only**
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2012

Ancient History › Vedic Period

easy

Q73. The religion of early Vedic Aryans was primarily of

- (a) Bhakti
- (b) image worship and Yajnas
- (c) worship of nature and Yajnas**
- (d) worship of nature and Bhakti

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2012

Ancient History › Trade & Economy

moderate

Q82. With reference to the guilds (Shreni) of ancient India that played a very important role in the country's economy, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. Every guild was registered with the central authority of the State and the king was the chief administrative authority on them.
2. The wages, rules of work, standards and prices were fixed by the guild.
3. The guild had judicial powers over its own members.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below :

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c)

— 2011 —

UPSC 2011

Ancient History › Trade & Economy

moderate

Q56. India maintained its early cultural contacts and trade links with Southeast Asia across the Bay of Bengal. For this pre-eminence of early maritime history of Bay of Bengal,

which of the following could be the most convincing explanation/explanations ?

- (a) As compared to other countries, India had a better ship-building technology in ancient and medieval times
- (b) The rulers of southern India always patronized traders, brahmin priests and buddhist monks in this context
- (c) Monsoon winds across the Bay of Bengal facilitated sea voyages**
- (d) Both (a) and (b) are convincing explanations in this context

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2011

Ancient History › Indus Valley Civilization

easy

Q92. Regarding the Indus Valley Civilization, consider the following statements :

1. It was predominantly a secular civilization and the religious element, though present, did not dominate the scene.
2. During this period, cotton was used for manufacturing textiles in India.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2**
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2011

Ancient History › Vedic Period

moderate

Q100. The "dharma" and "rita" depict a central idea of ancient Vedic civilization of India. In this context, consider the following statements:

1. Dharma was a conception of obligations and of the discharge of one's duties to oneself and to others.
2. Rita was the fundamental moral law governing the functioning of the universe and all it contained.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2**
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c)

— 2010 —

UPSC 2010

Ancient History › Buddhism & Jainism

moderate

Q141. Why did Buddhism start declining in India in the early medieval times ?

1. Buddha was by that time considered as one of the incarnations of Vishnu and thus became a part of Vaishnavism.
2. The invading tribes from Central Asia till the time of last Gupta king adopted Hinduism and persecuted Buddhists.
3. The Kings of Gupta dynasty were strongly opposed to Buddhism.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct ?

- (a) 1 only**
- (b) 1 and 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a)

— 2008 —

UPSC 2008

Ancient History › Science & Technology

easy

Q46. What does Baudhayana theorem (Baudhayana Sulva Sutra) relate to?

- (a) Lengths of sides of a right-angled triangle**
- (b) Calculation of the value of pi
- (c) Logarithmic calculations
- (d) Normal distribution curve

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2006

Ancient History › Science & Technology

moderate

Q38. Match List – I with List – II and select the correct answer using the code given below the lists:

List – I (Finding / Invention / Calculation)

A. Time taken by the Earth to orbit the Sun

B. Calculation of the value of 'pi'

C. Invention of the digit zero

D. The game of snakes and ladders

List – II (Ancient Indian Scholar)

1. Aryabhata

2. Bhaskaracharya

3. Budhayana

4. Gyandev

Code:

(a) A 2 B 4 C 1 D 3

(b) A 2 B 3 C 1 D 4

(c) A 1 B 3 C 2 D 4

(d) A 1 B 4 C 2 D 3

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2006

Ancient History › Post-Gupta & Early Medieval Dynasties

easy

Q117. Who among the following laid the foundation of Rashtrakuta Empire?

(a) Amoghavarsha I

(b) Dantidurga

(c) Dhruva

(d) Krishna I

Answer: (b)

Q129. Between

which of the following was the ancient town of Takshasila located?

- (a) Indus and Jehelum**
- (b) Jhelum and Chenab
- (c) Chenab and Ravi
- (d) Ravi and Beas

Answer: (a)

Q130. With reference to the invaders in ancient India,

which one of the following is the correct chronological order?

- (a) Greeks – Sakas – Kushans**
- (b) Greeks – Kushans – Sakas
- (c) Sakas – Greeks – Kushans
- (d) Sakas – Kushans – Greeks

Answer: (a)

Q131. Consider the following statements:

1. The Ikshvaku rulers of southern India were antagonistic towards Buddhism.
2. The Pala rulers of Eastern India were patrons of Buddhism.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only**
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2006

Ancient History › Gupta Empire

easy

Q144. The Allahabad Pillar inscription is associated with

which one of the following?

- (a) Mahapadma Nanda
- (b) Chandragupta Maurya
- (c) Ashoka
- (d) Samudragupta**

Answer: (d)

— 2005 —

UPSC 2005

Ancient History › Mahajanapadas & Early Kingdoms

easy

Q22. Who among the following was not a contemporary of the other three?

- (a) Bimbisara
- (b) Gautama Buddha
- (c) Milinda**
- (d) Prasenjit

Answer: (c)

— 2004 —

UPSC 2004

Ancient History › Foreign Travellers & Accounts

easy

Q24. Consider the following statements:

- 1. The Chinese pilgrim Fa-Hien attended the fourth Great Buddhist Council held by Kanishka.**
- 2. The Chinese pilgrim Hiuen-Tsang met Harsha and found him to be antagonistic to Buddhism.**

Which of these statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2**

Answer: (d)

Q26. With reference to ancient Jainism,

which one of the following statements is correct?

- (a) Jainism was spread in South India under the leadership of Sthalabahu
- (b) The Jains who remained under the leadership of Bhadrabahu were called Svetambaras after the Council held at Pataliputra
- (c) Jainism enjoyed the patronage of the Kalinga king Kharavela in the first century BC**
- (d) In the initial stage of Jainism, the Jains worshipped images unlike Buddhists

Answer: (c)

— 2003 —

Q43. Consider the following statements:

- 1. Vardhamana Mahavira's mother was the daughter of Lichchhavi chief Chetaka.**
- 2. Gautama Buddha's mother was a princess from the Kosha-lan dynasty.**
- 3. Parshvanatha, the 23rd Tirthankara, belonged to Banaras.**

Which of these statements is/are correct?

- (a) Only 1
- (b) Only 2
- (c) 2 and 3**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c)

Q70. Consider the following statements:

- 1. The last Mauryan ruler, Brihadratha was assassinated by his commander-in-chief, Pushyamitra Sunga.**
- 2. The last Sunga king, Devabhuti was assassinated by his Brahmana minister Vasudeva Kanva who usurped the throne.**
- 3. The last ruler of the Kanva dynasty was deposed by the Andhra's.**

Which of these statements is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) Only 2
- (c) Only 3
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 2003

Ancient History › Post-Gupta & Early Medieval Dynasties

easy

Q93. Emperor Harsha's southward march was stopped on the Narmada River by

- (a) Pulakesin-I
- (b) Pulakesin-II**
- (c) Vikramaditya-I
- (d) Vikramaditya-II

Answer: (b)

— 2002 —

UPSC 2002

Ancient History › Indus Valley Civilization

moderate

Q15. Match List I (Ancient site) with List II (Archaeological finding) and select the correct answer using the codes given below the lists:

List I (Ancient site)

- A. Lothal
- B. Kalibangan
- C. Dholavira
- D. ——— (site with Banawali inscription)

List II (Archaeological finding)

- 1. Ploughed field
- 2. Dockyard
- 3. Terracotta replica of a plough
- 4. An inscription comprising ten large-sized signs of the Banawali Harappan script

Codes:

- (a) A-1, B-2, C-3, D-4
- (b) A-2, B-1, C-2, D-4**
- (c) A-1, B-2, C-3, D-4
- (d) A-2, B-1, C-3, D-4

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2002

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

easy

Q35. The ancient Indian play Mudrarakshasa of Visakhadutt has its subject on

- (a) a conflict between Gods and Demons of ancient Hindu lore
- (b) a romantic story of an Aryan prince and a tribal woman
- (c) the story of the power struggle between two Aryan tribes
- (d) the court intrigues at the time of Chandragupta Maurya**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 2001

Ancient History › Post-Gupta & Early Medieval Dynasties

easy

Q28. Assertion (A): Harshavardhana convened the Prayag Assembly.

Reason (R): He wanted to popularise only the Mahayana form of Buddhism.

- (a) Both A and R are individually true, and R is the correct explanation of A
- (b) Both A and R are individually true, but R is NOT a correct explanation of A
- (c) A is true, but R is false**
- (d) A is false, but R is true

Answer: (c)

UPSC 2001

Ancient History › Post-Gupta & Early Medieval Dynasties

easy

Q36. Which one of the Chola kings conquered Ceylon?

- (a) Aditya I
- (b) Rajaraja I**
- (c) Rajendra
- (d) Vijayalaya

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2001

Ancient History › Buddhism & Jainism

moderate

Q41. Who among the following presided over the Buddhist Council held during the reign of Kanishka at Kashmir?

- (a) Parsva
- (b) Nagarjuna
- (c) Sudraka
- (d) Vasumitra**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 2001

Ancient History › Indus Valley Civilization

easy

Q47. Which one of the following animals was NOT represented on the seals and terracotta art of the Harappan culture?

- (a) Cow**
- (b) Elephant
- (c) Rhinoceros
- (d) Tiger

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2000

Ancient History › Post-Mauryan & Foreign Invasions

easy

Q18. The practice of military governorship was first introduced in India by the

- (a) **Greeks**
- (b) Shakas
- (c) Parthians
- (d) Mughals

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2000

Ancient History › Post-Mauryan & Foreign Invasions

easy

Q23. Which one of the following dynasties was ruling over North India at the time of Alexander's invasion?

- (a) **Nanda**
- (b) Maurya
- (c) Sunga
- (d) Kanva

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2000

Ancient History › Buddhism & Jainism

moderate

Q90. Assertion (A): The emphasis of Jainism on non-violence (ahimsa) prevented agriculturalists from embracing Jainism.

Reason (R): Cultivation involved killing of insects and pests.

- (a) **Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A**
- (b) Both A and R are true, but R is not a correct explanation of A
- (c) A is true, but R is false
- (d) A is false, but R is true

Answer: (a)

UPSC 2000

Ancient History › Gupta Empire

moderate

Q91. Assertion (A): The origin of feudal system in ancient India can be traced to military campaigns.

Reason (R): There was considerable expansion of the feudal system during the Gupta period.

- (a) Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A
- (b) **Both A and R are true, but R is not a correct explanation of A**
- (c) A is true, but R is false
- (d) A is false, but R is true

Answer: (b)

UPSC 2000

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

easy

Q92. Assertion (A): Ashoka annexed Kalinga to the Mauryan Empire.

Reason (R): Kalinga controlled the land and sea routes to South India.

- (a) Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A**
- (b) Both A and R are true, but R is not a correct explanation of A
- (c) A is true, but R is false
- (d) A is false, but R is true

Answer: (a)

— 1999 —

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Post-Gupta & Early Medieval Dynasties

easy

Q1. One consistent feature found in the history of southern India was the growth of small regional kingdoms rather than large empires because of

- (a) the absence of minerals like iron
- (b) too many divisions in the social structure
- (c) the absence of vast areas of fertile land**
- (d) the scarcity of manpower

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Vedic Period

easy

Q11. The term 'Aryan' denotes

- (a) an ethnic group
- (b) a nomadic people
- (c) a speech group**
- (d) a superior race

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Gupta Empire

easy

Q23. Which one of the following ports handled the north Indian trade during the Gupta period?

- (a) Tamralipti**
- (b) Broach
- (c) Kalyan
- (d) Cambray

Answer: (a)

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Trade & Economy

moderate

Q38. From the third century AD when the Hun invasion ended the Roman Empire, the Indian merchants relied more and more on the

- (a) African trade
- (b) West European trade
- (c) Southeast Asian trade**
- (d) Middle Eastern trade

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Foreign Travellers & Accounts

moderate

Q49. The following persons came to India at one time or another:

I. Fa-Hien

II. I-Tsing

III. Megasthenes

IV. Hieun-Tsang

The correct chronological sequence of their visits is:

- (a) III, I, II, IV
- (b) III, I, IV, II**
- (c) I, III, II, IV
- (d) I, III, IV, II

Answer: (b)

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Mahajanapadas & Early Kingdoms

easy

Q63. Which one of the following was initially the most powerful city state of India in the 6th century B.C.?

- (a) Gandhar
- (b) Kamboj
- (c) Kashi**
- (d) Magadh

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1999

Ancient History › Post-Mauryan & Foreign Invasions

moderate

Q78. The Indo-Greek kingdom set up in north Afghanistan in the beginning of the second century BC was

- (a) Bactria**
- (b) Scythia
- (c) Zedrasia
- (d) Aria

Answer: (a)

— 1998 —

UPSC 1998

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

moderate

Q28. Assertion (A): According to Asoka's edicts, social harmony among the people was more important than religious devotion.

Reason (R): He spread ideas of equity instead of promotion of religion.

- (a) Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A**
- (b) Both A and R are true, but R is NOT a correct explanation of A
- (c) A is true, but R is false
- (d) A is false, but R is true

Answer: (a)

UPSC 1998

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

moderate

Q41. Which one of the following ancient Indian records is the earliest royal order to preserve food grains to be utilised during the crises in the country?

- (a) Sohagaura Copper-plate**
- (b) Rumminidei pillar-edict of Asoka
- (c) Prayaga-Prasasti
- (d) Mehrauli Pillar inscription of Chandra

Answer: (a)

UPSC 1998

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

moderate

Q58. The given map relates to

The original map is not available for this question.

- (a) Kaniska at the time of his death
- (b) Samudragupta after the close of his South Indian campaign
- (c) Asoka towards the close of his reign**
- (d) Empire of Thanesar on the eve of Harsha's accession

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1998

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

moderate

Q66. The Asokan major rock edicts which tell us about the Sangam Kingdom include rock edicts

- (a) I and X
- (b) I and XI
- (c) II and XIII**
- (d) II and XIV

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1998

Ancient History › Archaeology & Epigraphy

moderate

Q77. What is the correct chronological order in which the following appeared in India?

I. Gold coins

II. Punch-marked silver coins

III. Iron plough

IV. Urban culture

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) III, IV, I, II
- (b) III, IV, II, I
- (c) IV, III, I, II
- (d) IV, III, II, I**

Answer: (d)

— 1997 —

UPSC 1997

Ancient History › Mauryan Empire

easy

Q81. Which one of the following edicts mentions the personal name of Asoka?

- (a) Kalsi
- (b) Rummindei
- (c) Special Kalinga Edict
- (d) Maski**

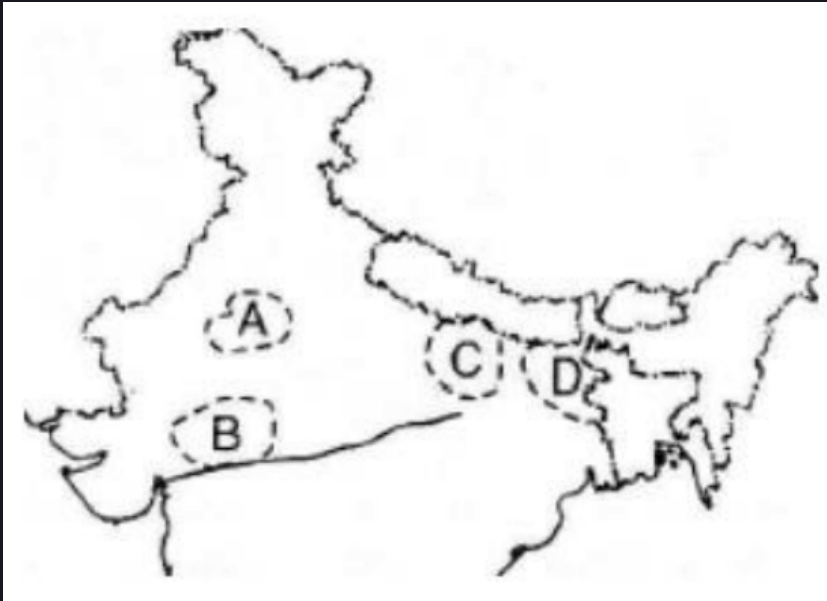
Answer: (d)

UPSC 1997

Ancient History › Mahajanapadas & Early Kingdoms

moderate

Q85. The following map shows four of the sixteen mahajanapadas that existed in ancient India. The places marked A, B, C and D respectively are



- (a) Matsya, Cedi, Kosala, Anga
- (b) Surasena, Avanti, Vatsa, Magadha
- (c) Matsya, Avanti, Vatsa, Anga**
- (d) Surasena, Cedi, Kosala, Magadha

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1997

Ancient History › Gupta Empire

easy

Q90. The silver coins issued by the Guptas were called

- (a) rupaka**
- (b) karshapana
- (c) dinara
- (d) pana

Answer: (a)

UPSC 1997

Ancient History › Trade & Economy

moderate

Q98. Which one of the following was a corporation of merchants in ancient India?

- (a) Chaturvedi Mangalam
- (b) Parishad
- (c) Ashtadikgaja
- (d) Manigrama**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 1997

Ancient History › Archaeology & Epigraphy

moderate

Q102. The Badami rock inscription of Pulakesin I is dated in the Saka year 465. If the same were to be dated in Vikrama Samvat, the year would be

- (a) 601**
- (b) 300
- (c) 330
- (d) 407

Answer: (a)

— 1996 —

UPSC 1996

Ancient History › Vedic Period

easy

Q28. The river most mentioned in early Vedic literature is

- (a) Sindhu**
- (b) Sutudri
- (c) Sarasvati
- (d) Ganga

Answer: (a)

UPSC 1996

Ancient History › Society, Law & Administration

moderate

Q41. In the context of ancient Indian society,

which one of the following terms does not belong to the category of the other three?

- (a) Kula
- (b) Vamsa
- (c) Kosa**
- (d) Gotra

Answer: (c)

UPSC 1996

Ancient History › Science & Technology

easy

Q47. Who among the following is known for his work on medicine during the Gupta period?

- (a) Saumilla
- (b) Sudraka
- (c) Shaunaka
- (d) Susrutha**

Answer: (d)

Q67. Match List I with List II

and select the correct answer by using the codes given below the lists:

List I

I. Visakhadatta

II. Varahamihira

III. Charaka

IV. Brahmagupta

List II

A) Medicine

B) Drama

C) Astronomy

D) Mathematics

(a) I – A, II – C, III – D, IV – B

(b) I – B, II – A, III – C, IV – D

(c) I – B, II – C, III – A, IV – D

(d) I – C, II – B, III – A, IV – B

Answer: (c)

— 1995 —

Q6. Who among the following was a Brahnavadini who composed some hymns of the Vedas?

(a) Lopamudra

(b) Gargi

(c) Leelavati

(d) Savitri

Answer: (a)

Q10. Match List I with List II

and select the correct answer by using the codes given below the lists:

List I (Eras)

I. Vikrama era

II. Saka era

III. Gupta era

IV. Kali era

List II (Reckoned from)

A) 3102 B.C.

B) 320 A.D.

C) 78 A.D.

D) 58 B.C.

E) 248 A.D.

- (a) I-B, II-D, III-E, IV-A
- (b) I-A, II-C, III-B, IV-D
- (c) I-D, II-E, III-B, IV-C
- (d) I-D, II-C, III-B, IV-A**

Answer: (d)

Q18. In Sanskrit plays written during the Gupta Period women and sudras speak

- (a) Sanskrit
- (b) Prakrit**
- (c) Pali
- (d) Sauraseni

Answer: (b)

Q21. The name by which Asoka is generally referred to in his inscriptions is

- (a) Chakravarti
- (b) Dharmadeva
- (c) Dharmakirti
- (d) Priyadarshini**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 1995

Ancient History › Trade & Economy

moderate

Q56. The term Yavanapriya, mentioned in ancient Sanskrit texts, denoted

- (a) a fine variety of Indian muslin
- (b) ivory
- (c) damsels sent to the Greek court for dance performance
- (d) pepper**

Answer: (d)

UPSC 1995

Ancient History › Science & Technology

easy

Q118. Zero was invented by

- (a) Aryabhata
- (b) Varahamihira
- (c) Bhaskara I
- (d) an unknown Indian**

Answer: (d)